

EMERGENCY SUB PLANS



MIDDLE SCHOOL ELA

VOLUME 1

Ten no-prep emergency lessons for the day you cannot be there. No novel required.



TIME-SAVING



NO PREP



ENGAGING



EFFECTIVE

- ✓ 10 complete lessons, one full class period each
- ✓ No novel, no textbook, no prep, no ELA background needed
- ✓ Every lesson has the words to say and a timing table
- ✓ All reading passages included and written for this pack
- ✓ Full answer keys with marking notes



DIGITAL VECTOR

Grades 6-8 • 57 pages • digitalvector.com.au

How This Pack Works

START HERE

You are holding ten complete emergency lessons for middle school English. Each one runs for a full class period, needs nothing but photocopies, and is written so that a substitute with no English background can teach it confidently.

Print the whole pack once and put it in a drawer. On the day you need it, you or your office staff pull one lesson, copy the student pages, and it is done.

What every lesson contains

PAGE	WHAT IT IS	WHO IT IS FOR
1	Teacher briefing. Timing table, the exact words to say, the three questions students will ask with the answers written out, and what to do with early finishers.	The substitute. Keep this page.
2	Reading or task page. The passage or material for the lesson, with numbered paragraphs for easy reference.	Copy for students.
3	Question page. Six to eight questions with writing space built in.	Copy for students.
4	Go further page. Extension task and a challenge for students who finish early.	Copy for students.
5	Answer key. Every answer worked out, plus marking notes and the wrong answers to expect.	The substitute. Keep this page.

THE ONE THING THAT MAKES THIS DIFFERENT

Most sub plans hand the substitute a worksheet and hope. That fails the moment a student raises a hand and asks a question about the content.

Every briefing page in this pack lists the three questions students actually ask in that lesson, with plain-language answers already written down. The substitute does not need to know anything about English to give a correct, confident answer.

Reading level and grouping

Passages sit in the grades 6 to 8 band. Every lesson works as independent silent work, as partner work, or read aloud by the substitute. The briefing page tells the substitute how to run all three.

Substitute Quick Start

FOR THE SUBSTITUTE

If you have five minutes before the bell, read this page and nothing else. It is enough.

IN THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

1. Find the lesson the teacher left, or pick any lesson from the index on the next page. They are independent. Order does not matter.
2. Copy the three student pages, one set per student.
3. Keep the briefing page and the answer key. Do not photocopy those.
4. Read the briefing page. It has a timing table and the words to say.

How the period runs, every time

MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
0-5	Students settle. You read the opening lines from the briefing page out loud. Hand out the student pages.
5-15	Students read the passage or task page. Silent, partner, or read aloud by you. Your choice.
15-40	Students work through the question page. You circulate.
40-50	Anyone finished moves to the Go Further page. Collect everything with two minutes to go.

IF A STUDENT ASKS YOU SOMETHING YOU CANNOT ANSWER

Check the briefing page first. The three most common questions for that lesson are already answered there.

If it is not there, this always works and is always true: *"Write down your best answer and put a star next to it. Your teacher will look at the starred ones."* Students accept this. It is also genuinely useful feedback for the returning teacher.

Three things that keep the room calm

- **Give a finish time, not a page count.** "Pens down at twenty past" works better than "finish page three."
- **Everyone gets the Go Further page.** Handing it out only to fast finishers reads as a reward and creates friction. Hand out all three pages at once.
- **Collect the work.** Students work harder when the paper is going somewhere. Put the pile on the teacher's desk.

NOTE FOR THE RETURNING TEACHER

Every lesson in this pack is a standalone skill lesson, not part of a sequence. Nothing here assumes a novel, a unit, or prior content. You can use any lesson at any point in the year without breaking your planning.

Lesson Index

ALL TEN LESSONS

Every lesson is independent. Teach them in any order. Each one is five pages in this pack: briefing, two student pages, a go further page, and an answer key.

#	LESSON	SKILL	CCSS	TIME
1	The Map Nobody Believed	Close reading and citing evidence	RI.6-8.1	40-50 min
2	What Is This Actually About?	Central idea and objective summary	RI.6-8.2	40-50 min
3	Word Attack	Context clues, roots, and prefixes	L.6-8.4	35-45 min
4	Take It Apart	Claim, evidence, and reasoning in an argument	RI.6-8.8	45-55 min
5	Two Reporters, One Fire Drill	Point of view, bias, and word choice	RI.6-8.6	45-55 min
6	The Six-Sentence Story	Narrative writing with a story spine	W.6-8.3	45-55 min
7	Sentence Surgery	Fragments, run-ons, and comma repair	L.6-8.1-2	35-45 min
8	Figurative Language Detective	Metaphor, simile, and hyperbole	RL.6-8.4	40-50 min
9	The Narrator Is Hiding Something	Point of view and reliability	RL.6-8.6	45-55 min
10	The One-Paragraph Case	Argument writing with CER	W.6-8.1	45-55 min

WHICH LESSON SHOULD I LEAVE?

Planned absence, want real work done: Lesson 4 or Lesson 10. Both produce writing you can grade.

Emergency, class you do not know well: Lesson 3 or Lesson 7. Both are self-contained skill practice with a low frustration ceiling.

Restless group, last period, day before a break: Lesson 6 or Lesson 8. Both have a creative hook and a visible finish line.

You will be out several days: Lessons 1, 2 and 4 run as a three-day sequence on informational text if you want them to, though each still stands alone.

Standards listed are Common Core State Standards for English Language Arts, grades 6-8. This resource is independently created and is not affiliated with or endorsed by any state agency or standards body.

The Map Nobody Believed

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students read a short true story and answer questions that can only be answered by going back into the text. The skill being practiced is proving an answer with a specific line, not guessing from memory. Every question on the student page names the paragraph where the evidence lives, so students always know where to look.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-15	Students read the passage. Silent reading works well here. If the class is restless, read it aloud yourself while they follow.
15-38	Students answer the questions. Remind them the paragraph numbers in each question are a hint, not decoration.
38-48	Go Further page for anyone finished. Circulate.
48-50	Collect all pages. Stack on the teacher's desk.

SAY THIS TO START

Today you are reading about a woman who mapped the bottom of the Atlantic Ocean without ever being allowed on a ship. Every question you are given can be answered from the text in front of you. If you find yourself guessing, you have not gone back and looked yet.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Is this a true story?"	Yes. Marie Tharp was a real geologist and the Mid-Atlantic Ridge is real. The passage was written for this lesson.
"Do I have to use full sentences?"	Yes for the explanation questions. The quote questions just need the words from the text plus the paragraph number.
"What does plate tectonics mean?"	It is the idea that Earth's outer shell is broken into large pieces that slowly move. Paragraph 9 says it in the passage.

FINISHED EARLY?

Turn to the Go Further page. It asks students to rank four pieces of evidence from strongest to weakest and defend the ranking. There is no single correct order, which is the point.

Read: The Map Nobody Believed

BEFORE YOU READ

Paragraphs are numbered. When a question says (par. 4), it is telling you exactly where to look. Use that.

The Map Nobody Believed

A true story about evidence

- 1 In 1952 a young woman sat in a basement office at Columbia University with a pile of paper strips in front of her. Her name was Marie Tharp. She had a geology degree at a time when almost no company would hire a woman geologist, so she took the job nobody else wanted: turning other people's numbers into pictures.
- 2 The numbers came from ships. Out in the Atlantic, research vessels dragged echo sounders behind them, bouncing sound off the seafloor and timing how long it took to come back. Deep water meant a long wait. Shallow water meant a short one. Line after line of these timings arrived at Tharp's desk as columns of figures. Tharp herself was not permitted on the ships, because women aboard were still considered bad luck at sea. She never saw the ocean she was mapping.
- 3 She drew it anyway. Working by hand, she turned each timing into a depth, plotted the depths along the ship's route, and joined them into a profile of the seafloor. After months, six profiles lay across her desk.
- 4 In every single one, at roughly the middle of the Atlantic, there was a V.
- 5 A valley. A deep notch running down the center of the ocean floor, in the same place, in all six.
- 6 Tharp knew what a V-shaped valley on land usually meant. It meant the ground was being pulled apart. If the same thing was happening on the seafloor, then the continents were not fixed in place. They were moving.
- 7 She took the finding to her colleague Bruce Heezen. He looked at the profiles and told her it was girl talk, that she had made an error somewhere and should check her work again. Tharp checked. The valley was still there.
- 8 What settled it was an accident. Heezen was running a separate project, plotting the locations of undersea earthquakes for an entirely different purpose. When someone laid that earthquake map over Tharp's valley, the dots fell into the notch like beads dropped into a groove. Two sets of measurements, collected by different people for different reasons, pointed at the same line on the ocean floor.
- 9 That line is now called the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. It is the seam where Earth's crust is splitting apart and new seafloor is being made. Tharp's hand-drawn profiles became some of the first hard evidence for plate tectonics, the idea that the surface of the planet is broken into slowly moving plates.
- 10 It took another decade for most geologists to accept it. Tharp's name did not appear on the 1959 paper that first announced the ridge to the world. She kept drawing. By 1977 she and Heezen had produced a painted map of the entire world ocean floor, and by then nobody was calling it girl talk.
- 11 Tharp said later that she had been handed a chance almost nobody gets: to find a blank space on the map and fill it in. She never did it from the deck of a ship. She did it from a basement, one paper strip at a time.

Questions: The Map Nobody Believed

Answer in the space given. When a question asks for words from the text, copy them exactly and add the paragraph number.

1 Why was Tharp never on the ships that collected her data? Copy the words from the text that tell you. (par. 2)

2 What did Tharp see in all six profiles, and where in the ocean was it? (par. 4-5)

3 What was Heezen's first reaction to her finding, and what did Tharp do about it? (par. 7)

4 Explain why the earthquake map made the finding much harder to argue with.

Think about who collected it and why. (par. 8)

5 The passage says Tharp "took the job nobody else wanted" (par. 1). Based on the whole passage, did that turn out badly for her? Give two pieces of evidence from the text.

6 In your own words, what does the last sentence mean when it says she did it "one paper strip at a time"?

TASK

Scientists do not treat all evidence as equally strong. Below are four things from the passage. Rank them from **1 (strongest evidence that the seafloor is splitting)** to **4 (weakest)**, then defend your top choice.

LETTER	THE EVIDENCE	YOUR RANK
A	A V-shaped valley appeared in the middle of the Atlantic in one profile.	----
B	The same valley appeared in all six profiles, in roughly the same place.	----
C	V-shaped valleys on land usually mean the ground is being pulled apart.	----
D	Undersea earthquakes, mapped separately for a different project, fell along the same line.	----

1 Which did you rank strongest, and why is it stronger than the others?

2 Which did you rank weakest? Explain what is missing from it.

CHALLENGE

Heezen told Tharp she had made an error. She checked, and she had not. Write two or three sentences: what should a scientist do when someone tells them their result is wrong? Is checking again a sign of weakness or a sign of good science?

Answer Key: The Map Nobody Believed

QUESTION PAGE

1. Women aboard ships were still considered bad luck at sea (par. 2). Accept any close copy of that phrase with the paragraph number. *Mark for the quote, not the phrasing. If they wrote it in their own words but got the reason right, give credit.*
2. A V-shaped valley, or deep notch, running down the middle of the Atlantic (par. 4-5). It appeared in the same place in all six profiles.
3. He called it girl talk and said she had made an error and should check her work. She checked, and the valley was still there (par. 7).
4. Because Heezen collected the earthquake data for a completely different project, so it could not have been shaped by wanting Tharp's valley to be real. Two independent measurements landing on the same line is much stronger than one. *Full credit needs the idea of independence. Common weak answer: "because there was more data." That is not the point. Nudge them toward who collected it and why.*
5. No, it turned out well. Evidence students may use: her profiles became some of the first hard evidence for plate tectonics (par. 9); she and Heezen produced a map of the whole world ocean floor by 1977 (par. 10); she got to fill in a blank space on the map (par. 11). *A well-argued "partly bad" answer is also fine if evidenced. Par. 10 says her name was left off the 1959 paper. Give full credit for a balanced answer that cites both sides.*
6. She built something enormous out of many tiny, slow, individual pieces of work, on her own, without dramatic moments. *Accept any answer that captures slow accumulation of small work.*

GO FURTHER PAGE

Ranking: There is no single correct order, but D and B are defensible as strongest and A as weakest. D is strongest because it is independent confirmation. B beats A because a repeated result is stronger than a single one. C is reasoning, not measurement. *Mark the justification, not the order. A student who ranks A first but defends it poorly scores lower than one who ranks C first and defends it well.*

Challenge: Look for: check again, look for the error honestly, but do not abandon a result just because someone senior disagrees. Checking is good science, not weakness.

IF STUDENTS FINISH EVERYTHING

Ask them to write the one question they would ask Marie Tharp. Collect these with the work. They are useful to the returning teacher.

What Is This Actually About?

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students read a short informational article, then practice two separate skills that are often confused: finding the central idea (what the whole text is about) and writing an objective summary (retelling it without sneaking in an opinion). The final task deliberately gives students four summaries and asks them to find the one that leaks an opinion.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-14	Students read the article. Partner reading works well here.
14-36	Students work through the question page in order. Question 4 is the hard one and should take the longest.
36-48	Go Further page. It is a sorting task, not more writing.
48-50	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

A central idea is not the topic. The topic of this article is backpacks. The central idea is the point the writer is making about backpacks. One of those is a word. The other is a sentence. Keep that difference in your head the whole lesson.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"What is the difference between a central idea and a main idea?"	Nothing important. Different textbooks use different words for the same thing. Tell them to treat them as identical.
"What does objective mean?"	It means you leave your own opinion out. Just report what the text said, not whether you agree with it.
"Can a summary have my opinion if I say I think?"	No. That is the whole point of question 4. An objective summary has no opinion in it at all, even a labeled one.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page has a four-way sort where students spot the summary that leaks an opinion. It takes about ten minutes and needs no marking on the spot.

Read: The Weight of the Thing

BEFORE YOU READ

As you read, keep one question in your head: **what is the writer trying to get me to understand?** That is the central idea. It is not the same as the topic.

The Weight of the Thing

Informational text • written for this lesson

- 1 Ask a school nurse what students complain about and shoulder pain comes up fast. Ask a physical therapist and you get the same answer. Ask the students and most of them shrug, because a heavy backpack does not feel like an injury. It feels like Tuesday.
- 2 The common guidance is that a loaded pack should sit somewhere between ten and fifteen percent of the person carrying it. For a student who weighs one hundred pounds, that is ten to fifteen pounds. A single hardcover textbook can run four pounds. Two of those, a laptop, a water bottle and a binder will clear the limit before lunch.
- 3 What the weight does is less obvious than it sounds. The body does not simply carry a heavy pack. It adjusts to it. Load someone's back and they lean forward to keep their balance, which shifts the work onto the muscles of the neck and upper back. Those muscles were not built for a steady all-day job, so they tire, and tired muscles ache. The ache is usually the first sign, and it arrives long before anything more serious.
- 4 Here is where it gets frustrating. The biggest single factor is not the weight at all. It is how the pack is worn. A pack slung on one shoulder forces the spine to curve sideways to compensate, loading one side of the body with all of it. A pack worn low, hanging near the hips, drags the shoulders backward and pulls the wearer off balance. The same bag, with the same books in it, becomes a substantially different problem depending on where it sits.
- 5 The fixes are unglamorous and they work. Use both straps. Tighten them until the pack sits flat against the upper back rather than swinging. Put the heaviest item closest to the spine, not out at the far edge where it acts like a lever. Clear the pack out on Friday, because a surprising fraction of the weight in any given bag is neither homework nor equipment but accumulated debris.
- 6 None of this is a secret. The advice has been printed on posters in nurse's offices for twenty years. The reason it does not stick is that one-shoulder carrying looks better, and looking better at thirteen beats a vague warning about your future spine almost every time.
- 7 Which may be the real finding here. The information is not missing. Students already know what they are supposed to do. The gap is not knowledge. It is that the cost of doing it is immediate and social, and the cost of ignoring it is slow and invisible, and humans are famously bad at that trade.

Questions: The Weight of the Thing

1 In one word, what is the topic of this article?

2 In one sentence, what is the central idea? What point is the writer making about that topic?

3 Paragraph 4 says the biggest factor is not the weight. What is it, and give one example the writer uses.

4 Write an objective summary of the whole article in three to four sentences.

Objective means no opinion of your own. Do not write whether you agree, whether it is interesting, or what you do with your own backpack.

5 Paragraph 7 says "the gap is not knowledge." Explain in your own words what the writer means.

6 The writer never tells students to stop carrying packs on one shoulder. Why do you think that is?

Go Further: Spot the Opinion

TASK

Below are four summaries of the article. **Three are objective. One has an opinion hidden in it.** Find the one that leaks, and underline the exact words that give it away.

#	SUMMARY
A	Heavy backpacks cause shoulder and back pain because the body leans forward to compensate, shifting work onto muscles that tire quickly. How the pack is worn matters more than what it weighs. The recommended fixes are simple, but students often ignore them.
B	The article explains that packs should be ten to fifteen percent of body weight and that most students exceed this. It describes how the body compensates for load and why one-shoulder carrying is worse. It ends by noting that the advice is widely known but rarely followed.
C	Backpack pain is a real problem with an obvious solution that students are frankly too vain to apply. The article lists the correct way to wear a pack and points out that everyone already knows it. The real issue is that appearance matters more to teenagers than their own health.
D	Loaded backpacks change how the body stands, which tires the neck and upper back. Position matters more than weight: one shoulder curves the spine, and a low pack pulls the wearer off balance. The article concludes that students know the advice but the cost of following it is immediate while the cost of ignoring it is not.

1 Which summary leaks an opinion? Write the letter and copy the words that give it away.

2 Rewrite that summary so it is objective. Keep the facts, remove the judgment.

CHALLENGE

Summary D is the longest and A is the shortest. Which is the better summary, and what makes a summary good? It is not length.

Answer Key: The Weight of the Thing

QUESTION PAGE

1. Backpacks. Accept school bags, backpack weight, or similar.

One word or a short phrase is fine. If they wrote a whole sentence here they have confused topic with central idea, which question 2 will confirm.

2. Something like: how a backpack is worn matters more than what it weighs, and students know the advice but do not follow it because the social cost is immediate.

Full credit for any sentence naming the writer's point. Half credit for "backpacks are heavy and cause pain", which is true but is only part of it.

3. How the pack is worn. Examples: one shoulder curves the spine sideways; a pack worn low near the hips drags the shoulders back and unbalances the wearer (par. 4).

4. Accept any three or four sentence retelling that covers: packs are often too heavy, the body compensates and tires, position matters more than weight, the advice is known but ignored.

The thing to mark hard is opinion leakage. Cross out any phrase like "I think", "stupidly", "they should just", or "this is important". Those are the target of this question.

5. Students are not failing because nobody told them. They already know what to do. The problem is doing it, not knowing it.

6. Open. Strong answers: the writer is explaining rather than lecturing; telling teenagers not to do something rarely works; the last paragraph says the problem is not a lack of being told.

Any reasonable answer that engages with par. 6-7 gets credit.

GO FURTHER PAGE

- 1.

C is the one that leaks. Giveaway words: "frankly too vain", "The real issue is", and treating appearance mattering as a criticism rather than a fact.

Students often pick D because it is longest, or A because it says "students often ignore them". A is fine: that is reporting what the article said, not judging it. That distinction is the lesson.

2. A rewrite of C along the lines of: the article states the advice is well known, and explains that students weigh immediate social cost against slow, invisible physical cost.

Challenge: D is the better summary. A good summary is judged on coverage and accuracy, not length. D captures the article's conclusion; A stops before it.

MARKING SHORTCUT

If you are short on time, mark question 4 only. It is the one that shows whether the skill landed. Everything else is scaffolding toward it.

Word Attack

TEACHER BRIEFING · KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students meet ten unfamiliar words inside a passage and work out what each one means without a dictionary. This is the single most useful reading skill there is, because no student will ever have a dictionary in the moment they need one. The passage was written so that every target word has real, usable context around it.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-4	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
4-13	Students read the passage straight through without stopping at the bold words. Tell them this explicitly.
13-34	Students work the question page. They may not use phones or dictionaries. That is the whole exercise.
34-44	Go Further page: building words from parts.
44-45	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

Ten words in this passage are in bold. You almost certainly do not know all of them, and that is the point. You are not allowed a dictionary today. What you are allowed is the rest of the sentence, which is what good readers actually use. Read the whole thing first without stopping. Then go back.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Can I just look it up?"	No. Working it out from context is the skill being practiced. Looking it up skips it.
"What if I get it a bit wrong?"	Close counts. If they get the general sense and the right positive or negative feel, that is a good answer.
"What is a root?"	The core part of a word that carries its meaning, which often comes from Latin or Greek. Example: <i>aqua</i> means water, so aquarium, aquatic and aqueduct are all about water.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page asks students to build and define six new words from roots and prefixes given in a table. It is a puzzle, not an essay.

Read: Night Shift at the Aquarium

BEFORE YOU READ

Ten words are in **bold**. Read the whole passage first **without stopping** at them. You will work them out afterward. No dictionaries, no phones.

Night Shift at the Aquarium

Narrative nonfiction • written for this lesson

- 1 The public leaves at six. By seven the building has gone quiet enough that Dana can hear the pumps, a low **incessant** hum that never stops, day or night, in every corner of the building. She has worked here four years and no longer notices it until a visitor mentions it.
- 2 Dana is a night keeper. Her job is to walk the tanks after closing and check that nothing has gone wrong, which mostly means checking that nothing has changed. A healthy tank is **monotonous**. The same fish do the same laps in the same order. When something is off, it is almost never dramatic. It is a fish resting closer to the bottom than usual, or a filter running a fraction louder.
- 3 The octopus is the exception. Every keeper who has worked a night shift has a story about the octopus, and the stories are **remarkably** similar: you look away, and it is somewhere it should not be. Octopuses are famous escape artists, and the aquarium's lid is weighted with two bricks for that reason.
- 4 Dana's first month, she was **skeptical** about the bricks. It seemed like an overreaction to her, an old story that keepers repeated to make the job sound more interesting than it was. Then she watched the animal lift the lid with three arms, hold it, and reach a fourth toward the gap. She stopped doubting the bricks.
- 5 Most of the shift is **meticulous** and dull. Water chemistry is logged to the second decimal place. Temperature, salinity and oxygen are recorded for every tank on a clipboard that has not been redesigned since 1998. The work rewards patience and punishes shortcuts, because the numbers only matter as a series. One reading tells you nothing. Thirty readings tell you a filter is failing.
- 6 Dana says the hardest part of the job is resisting the urge to **intervene**. A new keeper sees a fish behaving oddly and wants to act immediately, to net it, move it, treat it. Usually the right move is to write it down and look again in an hour. Most odd behavior is not a problem. Acting on all of it stresses the animal far more than the original oddity ever would.
- 7 There is one part of the shift that is neither dull nor **tedious**. Around three in the morning the building is completely dark except for the tanks themselves, which glow. Dana walks the main hall with no visitors, no noise but the pumps, and forty thousand gallons of lit blue water on both sides of her.
- 8 She says the **tranquility** of it is the reason she has never applied for a day position, even though the day shift pays slightly better and does not **disrupt** her sleep the way this one does.
- 9 At six in the morning the cleaners arrive, the lights come up, and the building becomes ordinary again. Dana signs the clipboard, notes anything worth **scrutiny** for the day team, and goes home to sleep while everyone else is starting.

Questions: Word Attack

For each bold word, write what you think it means **and** the clue in the passage that told you. No dictionaries.

#	WORD	PAR.	I THINK IT MEANS...	THE CLUE THAT TOLD ME
1	incessant	1		
2	monotonous	2		
3	remarkably	3		
4	skeptical	4		
5	meticulous	5		
6	intervene	6		
7	tedious	7		
8	tranquility	8		
9	disrupt	8		
10	scrutiny	9		

WHICH STRATEGY DID YOU ACTUALLY USE?

Tick every one you used at least once. Good readers switch between all four without noticing.

✓	STRATEGY	WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE IN YOUR HEAD
	Definition nearby	"The sentence literally tells me what it means."
	Contrast	"It says <i>neither dull nor</i> , so it must mean something like dull."
	Example given	"It lists <i>net it, move it, treat it</i> , so that is what the word covers."
	Word parts	"I recognize a piece of this word from another word I know."

11 Which word was easiest to work out, and what made the context so helpful?

12 Which was hardest? What would have helped you?

Go Further: Building Words From Parts

TASK

English builds words out of pieces. If you know the pieces, you can attack a word you have never seen. Use the tables to work out the six words at the bottom.

PREFIX	MEANS	ROOT	MEANS
inter-	between	ven / vent	come
dis-	apart, not	aqua	water
trans-	across	marine / mar	sea
sub-	under, below	spect / spec	look
re-	again, back	port	carry
in- / im-	not	cess / ceed	go, stop

WORD	BREAK IT INTO PARTS	WHAT IT MUST MEAN
submarine		
transport		
intervene		
inspect		
aquatic		
incessant		

CHALLENGE

Invent one new word using a prefix and a root from the tables above. Write the word, what it would mean, and use it in a sentence about the aquarium.

Answer Key: Word Attack

QUESTION PAGE • ACCEPT CLOSE MEANINGS

#	WORD	MEANING	THE CONTEXT CLUE
1	incessant	never stopping, constant	"never stops, day or night"
2	monotonous	the same over and over, unchanging	"same fish, same laps, same order"
3	remarkably	noticeably, strikingly	the stories are all alike
4	skeptical	doubting, not convinced	"seemed like an overreaction"; later "stopped doubting"
5	meticulous	extremely careful and precise	"logged to the second decimal place"; "punishes shortcuts"
6	intervene	step in and act	"net it, move it, treat it" vs. writing it down
7	tedious	boring, tiresome	paired with "dull" as the thing this part is NOT
8	tranquility	calm, peacefulness	dark hall, no visitors, no noise
9	disrupt	upset or interrupt	"the way this one does" to her sleep
10	scrutiny	close attention or inspection	something worth flagging to the day team

11-12. Open. No wrong answer.

Worth reading: which word students name as hardest tells the returning teacher where vocabulary support is needed.

GO FURTHER PAGE

WORD	PARTS	MEANING
submarine	sub + marine	under the sea
transport	trans + port	carry across
intervene	inter + vene	come between
inspect	in + spect	look into
aquatic	aqua + tic	to do with water
incessant	in + cess + ant	not stopping

WATCH FOR THIS

Students often say *inspect* means "not look" because **in-** can mean "not". Both are real prefixes spelled the same way. Tell them: the meaning that makes sense in a real sentence is the right one. That is a genuinely useful rule.

Take It Apart

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students read a short opinion piece and pull it apart into its three moving parts: the claim (what the writer wants you to believe), the evidence (the facts offered), and the reasoning (the link between them). One paragraph in the article has evidence that does not actually support its claim. Finding it is the point of the lesson.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-14	Students read the opinion piece.
14-40	Question page. Question 5 is the hard one. Tell students in advance that one paragraph has a weak link, so they read hunting for it.
40-53	Go Further page: writing the counter-argument.
53-55	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

Every argument has three parts. The claim is what the writer wants you to believe. The evidence is the facts they give you. The reasoning is the sentence that connects the two, and it is the part writers most often leave out and hope you do not notice. Somewhere in this article, the evidence does not actually prove the claim. Your job is to find it.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Do I have to agree with the article?"	No. You can think the conclusion is right and the argument is badly made. Those are separate things, and noticing the difference is the skill.
"What is the difference between evidence and reasoning?"	Evidence is a fact. Reasoning is the sentence explaining why that fact proves the point. "Sales fell 30%" is evidence. "Which shows customers lost trust" is reasoning.
"Is the article real?"	It was written for this lesson. The general debate about school start times is real, but do not quote these numbers as fact.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page asks students to write the strongest possible argument for the opposite side, which is harder and more useful than agreeing.

Read: Start Later

BEFORE YOU READ

This is an **opinion piece**. The writer is trying to persuade you. Read it once for what it says, then a second time asking: *does each piece of evidence actually prove the thing it is attached to?*

Start Later

Opinion · written for this lesson

- 1 Our middle school starts at 7:45 in the morning. It should start at 8:45, and the argument for changing it is stronger than most people realize.
- 2 Start with the biology, because it is the part adults get wrong most often. During adolescence the body's internal clock shifts later. This is not laziness and it is not a choice. Sleep researchers have documented that teenagers naturally fall asleep later than younger children and later than adults, and that no amount of going to bed early fully overrides it. A teenager told to sleep at nine will frequently lie awake until eleven. Waking that same student at six is therefore not asking them to be disciplined. It is asking them to do something their body is actively working against.
- 3 The consequences show up in the building. Teachers at our school report that first period is the hardest to teach. Students are quieter, slower to answer, and more likely to put their heads down. Every teacher I asked said the same thing.
- 4 Later start times also improve safety. Studies of districts that moved their start times later have found reductions in crashes involving teenage drivers. Drowsy driving is a well-documented hazard, and a student who has slept an extra hour is a measurably safer driver.
- 5 And the change would improve grades. Last year our district's highest-performing middle school started at 8:30, the latest start time of any school in the district. The connection is obvious.
- 6 The usual objection is buses. Districts run tiered bus schedules, with high schools first and elementary schools later, so moving one school affects all of them. This is a real cost and it is not nothing. But it is a scheduling problem, and scheduling problems have solutions. Several districts have restructured their routes and absorbed the change within a single budget year.
- 7 The second objection is sports. Later dismissal means later practice and later games. This is true. It is also true that the number of students affected is smaller than the number of students in first period, which is all of them.
- 8 We are asking students to do their hardest thinking at the hour their bodies are least able to do it, and then treating the result as a discipline problem. One hour would fix a great deal of it.

Questions: Take It Apart

1 What is the writer's overall claim? Write it in one sentence.

2 Paragraph 2 gives evidence about the teenage body clock. What is the reasoning that connects it to the claim?

What does that fact prove about start times?

3 Paragraph 4 is about safety. Write the evidence and the reasoning separately.

Evidence = the fact. Reasoning = why it proves the point.

4 Paragraph 3 uses teacher reports as evidence. Is that strong or weak evidence? Explain.

5 One paragraph has evidence that does not actually prove its claim. Which one is it, and what is wrong with it?

This is the hardest question on the page. Take your time.

6 The writer admits two objections (par. 6 and 7). Does admitting them make the argument weaker or stronger? Why?

Go Further: Argue the Other Side

TASK

It does not matter what you personally think. Your job is to build the **strongest possible argument** that the school should keep its 7:45 start. Use the frame below. Anyone can disagree. The skill is disagreeing well.

PART	YOUR WRITING
Claim What you want the reader to believe.	
Evidence 1 A fact, example, or consequence.	
Reasoning 1 Why that fact proves your claim.	
Evidence 2	
Reasoning 2	
Their best point The strongest thing the other side says.	
Your answer to it	

CHALLENGE

Which side has the better argument, honestly? You are allowed to say the side you disagree with. Explain in two sentences what makes an argument good, separately from whether it is right.

Answer Key: Take It Apart

QUESTION PAGE

1. The school should move its start time from 7:45 to 8:45.
2. Because the teenage body clock naturally shifts later and cannot simply be overridden, an early start forces students to be awake and thinking when their bodies are least able to. So the start time, not the students, is the thing that should change.
3. **Evidence:** studies of districts that moved to later start times found fewer crashes involving teen drivers. **Reasoning:** more sleep means less drowsy driving, so a later start makes students safer.
4. Weak to moderate. It is real information but it is anecdotal, the sample is one school, and "every teacher I asked" does not say how many were asked or whether they were chosen at random.
Accept "strong" if the student argues teachers are direct observers and that firsthand reports count. The reasoning is what is being marked, not the verdict.
5. **Paragraph 5.** It claims later starts improve grades, and offers as evidence that the district's highest-performing school also has the latest start. That is a correlation, not a cause. The high-performing school could differ in dozens of other ways. The phrase "the connection is obvious" is doing the work that actual reasoning should be doing.
This is the target of the whole lesson. Students do not need the word correlation. Full credit for: "two things happening together does not mean one caused the other." Common wrong answer: paragraph 3, because it is anecdotal. That is a fair criticism but the evidence there does support the claim. Paragraph 5's does not.
6. Stronger. Naming the best objections shows the writer has considered them, and answering them is more convincing than pretending they do not exist.
Accept "weaker" if genuinely argued, e.g. par. 7 concedes the point without really answering it.

GO FURTHER PAGE

- Frame:** Strong student arguments for keeping 7:45 usually use: bus tiering costs and knock-on effects on elementary students; after-school jobs and childcare responsibilities; sports and activities ending after dark; parent work schedules and drop-off; students simply staying up an hour later so nothing is gained.
Mark the reasoning boxes hardest. Students find evidence easily and skip the link. An empty or repeated reasoning row is the thing worth a comment.
- Challenge:** Look for the distinction between an argument being *well made* and being *correct*. That distinction is the whole lesson.

Two Reporters, One Fire Drill

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students read two short accounts of exactly the same school event. No fact is contradicted between them. Everything that differs is word choice, what gets included, and what gets left out. The lesson makes bias visible as a set of specific, findable techniques rather than a vague accusation.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-13	Students read both accounts. Reading them aloud with two different students works very well here if the class will do it.
13-40	Question page. Question 3 (the word-swap table) is the engine of the lesson.
40-53	Go Further page: students write a third, neutral version.
53-55	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

You are about to read two reports of the same fire drill. Here is the important part: neither one is lying. Every fact in both is true. And they leave you with completely different impressions. By the end of this lesson you should be able to point at the exact words that did it.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Which one is the true one?"	Both. That is the point. No fact in either account is false. The difference is choice of words and choice of what to include.
"Is bias always bad?"	No. Everyone writes from a point of view. The problem is bias you cannot see. Once you can name it, you can read around it.
"Can I say both are bad?"	Yes, if they explain what a fairer version would look like. That is exactly what the Go Further page asks for.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page asks students to rewrite the event neutrally in five sentences, which is harder than it sounds and shows immediately whether they understood.

Read: Two Accounts of One Drill

BEFORE YOU READ

Two reporters from the same school newspaper covered the same fire drill. **Neither one is lying.** Every fact in both accounts is true.

Account A: Drill Exposes Serious Safety Gaps

By the school paper's news desk

- 1 Tuesday's fire drill took six minutes and forty seconds to clear the building, well over the district's four-minute target. Several classes were still filing out of the east wing when the all-clear was given.
- 2 The problem began at the east stairwell, where two classes attempted to descend at once and the flow stalled completely for nearly a minute. Students were left standing in a crowded stairwell while an alarm sounded, unsure whether to continue or wait.
- 3 Administration has run four drills this year. This was the slowest. Assistant Principal Rowe acknowledged the delay and said the east wing route would be reviewed.
- 4 A real fire does not wait for a route review.

Account B: Fourth Drill Runs Smoothly, One Bottleneck Noted

By the school paper's features desk

- 1 The school's fourth fire drill of the year was carried out on Tuesday, with the entire building evacuated in under seven minutes and no injuries reported.
- 2 Students moved quickly and quietly to their assigned areas, and teachers completed roll checks without incident. Staff described the atmosphere as orderly.
- 3 One congestion point was identified at the east stairwell, where two classes briefly converged. Assistant Principal Rowe said the route would be reviewed ahead of the next drill, calling the process "exactly what drills are for."
- 4 The school has now completed four drills this year, ahead of schedule.

Questions: Two Reporters, One Drill

1 Write down three facts that appear in both accounts.

2 What does Account A include that Account B leaves out? What does B include that A leaves out?

3 Both writers described the same things using different words. Fill in the table.

THE SAME FACT	ACCOUNT A'S WORDS	ACCOUNT B'S WORDS
How long it took		
The east stairwell		
The route review		
Four drills this year		

4 Account A ends with a one-sentence paragraph. What is it doing there, and is it a fact or an opinion?

5 If you only read Account B, what would you never find out?

Go Further: Write the Fair Version

TASK

Write a **third account** of the same drill in exactly five sentences. Include every fact from both versions. Use no word that pushes the reader toward a conclusion. Let them decide.

WORDS TO AVOID

Too negative: failed, exposed, stalled completely, serious, crowded, unsure, chaos, well over.

Too positive: smoothly, orderly, quickly and quietly, without incident, ahead of schedule, briefly.

Both lists are doing persuasion. A fair report uses neither.

1 Which was harder, writing neutrally or writing with a slant? Why do you think that is?

CHALLENGE

Both accounts are from the **same school newspaper**. Why might a news desk and a features desk cover the same event so differently? Give one reason that does not involve either writer lying.

Answer Key: Two Reporters, One Drill

QUESTION PAGE

- Any three of: the drill happened Tuesday; it was the fourth of the year; the building was evacuated in between six and seven minutes; two classes converged at the east stairwell; Assistant Principal Rowe said the route would be reviewed.
- A only:** the district's four-minute target; that this was the slowest drill of the four; students standing in a stairwell unsure what to do; the closing opinion line. **B only:** no injuries; roll checks completed; staff describing it as orderly; Rowe's full quote; that the school is ahead of schedule on drills.
- The word-swap table:

SAME FACT	ACCOUNT A	ACCOUNT B
Duration	"six minutes forty seconds, well over the four-minute target"	"under seven minutes"
East stairwell	"the flow stalled completely", "crowded", "unsure"	"one congestion point", "briefly converged"
Route review	"acknowledged the delay"	"exactly what drills are for"
Four drills	"This was the slowest"	"ahead of schedule"

Note that A gives the precise time to make it sound long, and B rounds up to make it sound short. Same fact, opposite effect. That is worth pointing out to the class if there is time.

This table is the one to mark if you mark nothing else.

- It is a one-line editorial comment, and it is an opinion. It adds no new fact and exists purely to leave the reader alarmed.
- That the drill missed the district's four-minute target, that it was the slowest of the four, and that students were left standing in a stairwell not knowing what to do.

GO FURTHER PAGE

Neutral version: A good five-sentence version reports the date, the measured time alongside the four-minute target, the stairwell convergence, no injuries and completed roll checks, and Rowe's comment, using none of the loaded words from either list.

Mark by highlighting any word from the avoid list. Students find this genuinely hard, which is the useful part.

Challenge: A news desk reports problems and holds people to account; a features desk covers school life and community. Same facts, different job. Neither is lying.

The Six-Sentence Story

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students write a complete short story in exactly six sentences using a fixed frame. The severe length limit is the teaching device: it removes the blank-page problem, forces every sentence to do work, and produces a finished piece inside one period. Students who claim they cannot write usually can write six sentences.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-6	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages. Read the worked example aloud.
6-14	Students pick a story seed and fill in the planning boxes. Insist on planning before drafting.
14-34	Students draft their six sentences.
34-46	Go Further: the swap-and-improve page. Pair students up.
46-53	Volunteers read theirs aloud. This part is genuinely popular. Never force it.
53-55	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

You are writing a whole story today. Beginning, middle, end. Here is the catch: six sentences. Not five, not seven. Six. That sounds impossible and it is not, because you are being given the frame. Every sentence has a job. Your only decision is what goes in it.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Can I write seven?"	No. Say it lightly but hold the line. The limit is what makes the exercise work. If they have seven, tell them to combine two.
"Can it be about anything?"	Yes, within school rules. There are six story seeds on the page if they are stuck. Nothing violent, nothing about real classmates.
"What if my sentences are really long?"	That is allowed and it is a normal way students cheat the limit. It is fine. The frame still does its job.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page has students swap stories with a partner and apply three specific improvements. If nobody is available to swap with, they apply the three improvements to their own.

The Frame

THE SIX-SENTENCE SPINE

Every story ever told has roughly this shape. Each sentence below has one job. Do that job and you have a story.

#	ITS JOB	WHAT THAT MEANS
1	Once there was...	Introduce your character and their normal world. One detail only.
2	Every day...	What is routine for them. This makes the change matter.
3	Until one day...	Something breaks the routine. This is where the story actually starts.
4	Because of that...	The character does something about it. They must act, not just react.
5	Until finally...	The moment it turns. Success, failure, or something they did not expect.
6	And ever since then...	The new normal. How the world is different now.

WORKED EXAMPLE

1. Once there was a boy named Ravi who was the only person in his family who could not swim. **2.** Every day he sat on the hot concrete at the edge of the pool with a towel around his shoulders and told everyone he was fine. **3.** Until one day his little sister slipped off the ladder at the deep end. **4.** Because of that, Ravi went into eight feet of water without deciding to, and hauled her to the wall in a graceless, thrashing, entirely effective panic. **5.** Until finally he was standing in the shallow end coughing, holding a furious four-year-old who had not actually been in any danger at all. **6.** And ever since then Ravi has swum badly, loudly, and every single day.

STUCK? PICK A SEED.

A. Someone finds a key that does not belong to them. **B.** A person is very good at something nobody knows about. **C.** The last day of something. **D.** A promise that should not have been made. **E.** Someone returns to a place they left. **F.** A small lie that grows.

TWO RULES

Exactly six sentences. Not about real people at this school.

Plan and Draft

STEP 1 • PLAN (DO THIS FIRST, IN NOTE FORM)

My character

Name + one detail

Their normal

What breaks it

What they do

How it turns

STEP 2 • DRAFT YOUR SIX SENTENCES

1. Once there was

2. Every day

3. Until one day

4. Because of that

5. Until finally

6. And ever since

BEFORE YOU HAND IT IN

Count your sentences. If you have seven, combine two. If you have five, you have skipped a job in the frame.

Go Further: Make It Better

TASK

Swap with a partner. Read their six sentences, then apply the three fixes below **to their story**. If you have no partner, apply them to your own.

FIX 1 • KILL A WEAK VERB

Find the dulllest verb in the story (*was, went, got, said, looked, did*) and replace it with one that carries information. Not *walked* but *trudged, bolted, drifted*.

THEIR WEAK VERB	MY REPLACEMENT	WHY IT IS BETTER

FIX 2 • ADD ONE CONCRETE DETAIL

Find the vaguest sentence and add one thing a reader could see, hear or smell. Not *the room was messy* but *there were four cereal bowls on the windowsill*.

FIX 3 • CUT FIVE WORDS

Cross out five words anywhere in the story without losing any meaning. Every story has five. Write the sentence you cut from, before and after.

CHALLENGE

Sentence 6 is the hardest to write well because it must show change without announcing it. In the worked example, "swum badly, loudly, and every single day" shows Ravi changed without ever saying he stopped being afraid. Rewrite your own sentence 6 so it **shows** the change instead of **stating** it.

Answer Key and Marking Guide: Six-Sentence Story

THIS LESSON HAS NO RIGHT ANSWERS

It is a writing task. Below is a fast way to judge whether a story is working, which you can use while circulating without reading anything closely.

The 20-second check

LOOK FOR	WORKING	NOT WORKING YET
Sentence 3	Something actually changes	Still describing the character
Sentence 4	The character does something	Something happens <i>to</i> them again
Sentence 5	There is a turn or a result	The story just stops
Sentence 6	The world is different now	"And that was that" or a moral tacked on
Overall	You could retell it to someone	A situation, not a story

THE MOST COMMON PROBLEM, AND THE ONE THING TO SAY

By far the most frequent failure is sentence 4: the character does not act, something else happens to them again. The fix is one question, and it works nearly every time:

"What does your character *do* about it?"

Rubric, if you want to leave a mark

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	
4	Six sentences, all six jobs done, at least one specific concrete detail, and the ending shows change rather than stating it.
3	Six sentences, all six jobs done, story is clear and complete. This is a good outcome for one period.
2	Frame followed but one job missing, usually the character not acting in sentence 4.
1	A situation rather than a story, or the frame abandoned.

READING ALOUD

If time allows, ask for volunteers rather than calling on students. Six sentences is short enough that this moves fast, and it is usually the part of the lesson students enjoy most. Never require it.

Sentence Surgery

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students repair twenty broken sentences. The lesson deliberately teaches grammar as editing rather than as rules to memorize: students are given one test they can apply to any sentence, then given faulty sentences and asked to fix them. Everything needed is on the student pages, so you do not need to know the terminology.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages. Walk through the two worked examples on page 1 out loud.
5-12	Students read the repair guide and do the four practice items.
12-36	The twenty-item operating table. Students may work in pairs.
36-44	Go Further: the paragraph rebuild.
44-45	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

There is one test that catches most broken sentences, and you already know how to do it. Read the group of words out loud on its own, with nothing around it. If it sounds like someone stopped talking too early, it is a fragment. If it sounds like they never took a breath, it is a run-on. Your ear is better at this than any rule you have been taught.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"How do I know if it needs a comma or a period?"	If both halves could stand alone as sentences, a comma alone is wrong. Use a period, a semicolon, or a comma plus and, but, so, or, for, nor, yet.
"Are fragments always wrong?"	In formal writing, yes. In fiction, writers use them deliberately. Today the task is to fix them, so treat them as errors.
"Is there more than one right answer?"	Yes, for most of them. The answer key gives one good repair per item and any repair that fixes the problem is correct.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page gives a paragraph with all punctuation removed. Students rebuild it. It takes about eight minutes and is harder than the twenty items.

The Repair Guide

THE ONE TEST

Read the group of words **out loud, on its own**. Then ask: does it have someone or something doing something, and does it feel finished? If yes, it is a sentence. Everything below is what happens when the answer is no.

Problem 1 • The fragment

A piece of a sentence pretending to be a whole one. It stops too early.

	BROKEN	FIXED
Missing the doing	The dog behind the fence at the end of our street.	The dog behind the fence at the end of our street barks all night .
Starts with a joining word	Because the bus was late again.	We missed first period because the bus was late again.

Words that create this problem when a sentence starts with them: *because, although, when, while, if, since, after, before, unless, until*. They are not banned. They just need a second half.

Problem 2 • The run-on

Two complete sentences shoved together with nothing, or with only a comma. The comma version has a name: a comma splice. It is the single most common error in student writing.

	BROKEN	THREE WAYS TO FIX IT
Comma splice	The power went out, we finished the test by phone light.	...out. We finished... / ...out; we finished... / ...out, so we finished...

THE COMMA-SPLICE RULE, IN ONE LINE

If the words on **both** sides of your comma could stand alone as sentences, a comma by itself is not enough. Use a period, a semicolon, or add **and, but, so, or, for, nor, yet**.

WARM-UP • LABEL EACH ONE F (FRAGMENT), R (RUN-ON), OR OK

Running down the hallway with her shoes in one hand.	----
The gym flooded last winter, nobody has fixed the drain since.	----
Although nobody asked him, Marcus explained the entire plot.	----
Whenever the fire alarm goes off during lunch.	----

The Operating Table

Twenty patients. For each one write **F**, **R** or **OK** in the first column. If it is F or R, rewrite it correctly on the line underneath. Some are already healthy. Leave those alone.

#	F/R/OK	PATIENT • REWRITE UNDERNEATH IF BROKEN
1		My brother eats cereal for dinner, he says it saves time. _____
2		Because the practice was cancelled at the last minute. _____
3		The library closes at four on Fridays. _____
4		She checked her bag twice she still forgot her calculator. _____
5		A cracked screen, a dead battery, and no charger anywhere. _____
6		When the substitute finally found the attendance sheet. _____
7		We waited outside for an hour, the doors were locked the whole time. _____
8		Nobody on the bus said anything about it. _____
9		Running late, missing the first question, and losing my pen. _____
10		The printer jammed again, so we handed it in by email. _____
11		Although she had studied every night that week. _____
12		The cafeteria ran out of forks nobody seemed surprised. _____
13		He apologized, and then he did exactly the same thing again. _____
14		Under the bleachers behind the old scoreboard. _____
15		I finished the book in two days it was that good. _____
16		If you leave your locker open all weekend. _____
17		The field was too wet, the game was moved to Thursday. _____
18		Everyone in my family snores except me. _____
19		Waiting in the office with a note she had not read yet. _____
20		The alarm went off at six, I did not get up until seven. _____

Go Further: Rebuild the Paragraph

TASK

Every period, comma and capital letter has been stripped out of the paragraph below. Rebuild it. Mark your capitals by circling the letter and write your punctuation straight onto the text.

the school's vending machine has been broken since october nobody has reported it because everybody assumes somebody else already did the machine still takes money it just does not release anything a handwritten sign appeared in november it said out of order in red marker the sign fell off within a week by january students had stopped trying the machine sits in the corner of the hall collecting dust and occasionally a dollar from someone new who has not yet learned

1 How many sentences did you end up with?

2 Was there a place where two different rebuilds would both be correct? Where, and what are the two versions?

CHALLENGE

Writers sometimes use fragments **on purpose**, for effect. Look at these two:

The machine sits in the corner of the hall collecting dust. And a dollar. Occasionally.

Those last two are fragments and they work. Explain in two sentences why a writer might break the rule deliberately, and why that is different from breaking it by accident.

Answer Key: Sentence Surgery

WARM-UP (PAGE 1)

1 F • 2 R (comma splice) • 3 OK • 4 F

THE OPERATING TABLE • ANY REPAIR THAT FIXES THE PROBLEM IS CORRECT

#		ONE GOOD REPAIR
1	R	...for dinner. He says... / ...dinner; he says... / ...dinner, and he says...
2	F	Because the practice was cancelled at the last minute, we went home early.
3	OK	—
4	R	She checked her bag twice, but she still forgot her calculator.
5	F	She had a cracked screen, a dead battery, and no charger anywhere.
6	F	When the substitute finally found the attendance sheet, half the period was gone.
7	R	We waited outside for an hour. The doors were locked the whole time.
8	OK	—
9	F	The morning was running late, missing the first question, and losing my pen. (Or add a subject and verb.)
10	OK	— comma + so is correct
11	F	Although she had studied every night that week, the test still surprised her.
12	R	The cafeteria ran out of forks. Nobody seemed surprised.
13	OK	— comma + and is correct
14	F	The lost ball was under the bleachers behind the old scoreboard.
15	R	I finished the book in two days; it was that good.
16	F	If you leave your locker open all weekend, do not expect to find your lunch.
17	R	The field was too wet, so the game was moved to Thursday.
18	OK	—
19	F	She was waiting in the office with a note she had not read yet.
20	R	The alarm went off at six, but I did not get up until seven.

GO FURTHER • REBUILT PARAGRAPH

The school's vending machine has been broken since October. Nobody has reported it, because everybody assumes somebody else already did. The machine still takes money; it just does not release anything. A handwritten sign appeared in November. It said OUT OF ORDER in red marker. The sign fell off within a week. By January, students had stopped trying. The machine sits in the corner of the hall, collecting dust and occasionally a dollar from someone new who has not yet learned.

Q1. Eight sentences in this version. Seven or nine can both be correct depending on joins.

Q2. Several. "...it just does not release anything" works as a semicolon, a period, or a comma plus *but*. Any of those is right.

IF A STUDENT ARGUES WITH THE KEY

They are often correct. Multiple repairs work for most items. Ask them to read their version out loud. If it sounds finished and does not run two sentences together, mark it right.

Figurative Language Detective

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students identify six kinds of figurative language in short original texts, then do the harder half: explain what each one actually achieves. Naming a simile is easy and nearly worthless on its own. Explaining why the writer chose it is the skill, and the question page is weighted toward that.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-12	Students read the reference box and the poem.
12-36	Question page. Remind them that <i>what it means</i> is worth more than <i>what it is called</i> .
36-48	Go Further: writing their own.
48-50	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

Figurative language means saying something in a way that is not literally true, in order to make it land harder. If I say the classroom was an oven, nobody calls the fire department. You already understand all of this. Today you are learning to name it and, more importantly, to explain what it does.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"What is the difference between a metaphor and a simile?"	A simile uses <i>like</i> or <i>as</i> . A metaphor says it directly. "Brave as a lion" is a simile. "He was a lion" is a metaphor.
"Is hyperbole the same as lying?"	No. Hyperbole is obvious exaggeration that nobody is meant to believe. "I have told you a million times" is hyperbole, not a false statement.
"How do I explain the effect?"	Ask what picture or feeling it creates that the plain version would not. "The line crawled" makes you feel the boredom. "The line moved slowly" does not.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page asks students to write their own figurative descriptions of ordinary school things, then rewrite one badly on purpose to show what makes the difference.

Read: The Reference and the Poem

NAME	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLE
Simile	Compares two things using <i>like</i> or <i>as</i> .	The hallway was as loud as a train platform.
Metaphor	Says one thing is another. No <i>like</i> , no <i>as</i> .	Third period is a waiting room.
Personification	Gives human behavior to something that is not human.	The old bus groaned up the hill and refused the corner.
Hyperbole	Obvious exaggeration, not meant to be believed.	My backpack weighs more than the school.
Idiom	A phrase whose meaning is not its literal words.	She threw in the towel. (Nobody threw a towel.)
Symbol	An object that stands for a bigger idea.	An empty chair standing for a person who is gone.

Last Bell, Friday

Poem • written for this lesson

- 1 The clock above the whiteboard has been lying all afternoon,
- 2 dragging its hands through wet cement,
- 3 while outside the window a whole summer waits in the parking lot
- 4 like a dog that has heard the keys.
- 5 Ms. Alvarez is still talking. She is a lighthouse
- 6 and we are boats already halfway home.
- 7 My pencil has written the same word four times.
- 8 My backpack weighs eleven thousand pounds.
- 9 Then the bell, and the room empties itself so fast
- 10 that the door gives up and stays open,
- 11 and on my desk, alone, one blue eraser
- 12 sits where I was.

TWO SHORT PROSE LINES, ALSO FOR THE QUESTIONS

- A. By the third week of January the whole gym had thrown in the towel on the leaking roof and put a bucket under it.
- B. The vending machine hummed to itself in the empty hall, keeping its own company.

Questions: Figurative Language Detective

For each one, **name it** and then **explain what it does**. The explanation is worth more than the name.

#	THE WORDS	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT DOES / WHY THE WRITER CHOSE IT
1	"dragging its hands through wet cement" (line 2)		
2	"like a dog that has heard the keys" (line 4)		
3	"She is a lighthouse / and we are boats" (5-6)		
4	"weighs eleven thousand pounds" (line 8)		
5	"the door gives up" (line 10)		
6	"thrown in the towel" (prose A)		
7	"keeping its own company" (prose B)		

8 Line 1 says the clock "has been lying." A clock cannot lie. What does the speaker actually mean?

9 The poem ends with one blue eraser sitting where the speaker was. What might the eraser symbolize? There is more than one good answer.

10 Pick the one image in this poem you think works best. Quote it and explain what it made you see or feel.

TASK

Write your own figurative description for each ordinary thing below. Use the type named in the middle column. Aim for something nobody else in the room would write.

THE ORDINARY THING	USE THIS TYPE	YOUR VERSION
A hallway between classes	Simile	
Monday morning	Metaphor	
An old classroom heater	Personification	
How long a test felt	Hyperbole	
The cafeteria at noon	Your choice	

NOW BREAK ONE ON PURPOSE

Take your best line from above and rewrite it **badly**. Use the most obvious, worn-out comparison you can think of (*as cold as ice, as busy as a bee, quiet as a mouse*).

MY GOOD VERSION	MY DELIBERATELY BAD VERSION

1 What exactly makes the bad one worse? Be specific. "It is boring" is not specific.

CHALLENGE

"As cold as ice" was once a brand new comparison that somebody invented. Why do comparisons wear out over time? What does that tell you about where good writing comes from?

Answer Key: Figurative Language Detective

QUESTION PAGE • MARK THE EXPLANATION COLUMN HARDER THAN THE NAMING COLUMN

#	IT IS	WHAT IT DOES
1	Personification (also metaphor)	Gives the clock human hands that are stuck in cement. Makes time feel physically heavy and slow rather than just late.
2	Simile	The summer is desperate and coiled, waiting for one signal. Anyone who has seen a dog react to keys knows the exact feeling instantly.
3	Metaphor (extended)	The teacher is fixed, bright and trying to guide; the students have already drifted. It shows the gap between them without blaming either.
4	Hyperbole	Nobody believes eleven thousand pounds. It conveys exhaustion at the end of a week, not weight.
5	Personification	The door is so overwhelmed it quits. Makes the emptying room feel like a force rather than an event.
6	Idiom	Means gave up. Everyone understands it and nobody pictures a towel.
7	Personification	The machine is lonely and self-contained, which makes the hall feel emptier than saying "the hall was empty".

8. The clock is going more slowly than it feels like it should, so the speaker feels betrayed by it. Time is not passing the way the clock claims.

9. Open. Strong answers: what gets left behind; the speaker's absence made visible; the smallness of one person in an empty room; an eraser specifically, as the thing that removes traces, left behind as a trace.

Any answer connected to the text earns full credit. There is no single intended reading.

10. Open. Mark the explanation, not the choice.

GO FURTHER PAGE

The five lines: Anything original and specific. The marker of a good answer is that it could not have been written about anything else.

Break it on purpose: Look for specificity in the explanation. Strong answers say the bad version is one everyone has heard, so the reader's eye slides over it without forming a picture.

Challenge: Comparisons wear out because repetition makes them invisible: the reader stops picturing anything and just recognizes the phrase. Good writing therefore comes from looking at the actual thing rather than reaching for the nearest familiar phrase.

QUICK WIN IF THE ROOM IS FLAT

Read four or five of the student hyperboles aloud with no names attached. It takes two minutes and reliably lifts the room.

The Narrator Is Hiding Something

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students read a short story told by a narrator who is not telling the whole truth, and hunt for the places where the story leaks past him. This moves students from "who is telling the story" to the far more useful question: "what is this narrator not saying, and how can I tell?" The evidence is all in the text and is findable.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-5	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages.
5-15	Students read the story. Silent reading is best here so the clues land individually.
15-40	Question page. Question 4 is where the lesson lands.
40-53	Go Further: rewriting a scene from the other character's point of view.
53-55	Collect all pages.

SAY THIS TO START

Every story has someone telling it, and that person decides what you get to know. Today's narrator is a twelve-year-old named Theo, and Theo is not lying to you exactly. He is telling you the version he can live with. Your job is to spot the places where the truth gets out anyway.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Is the narrator the author?"	No. The narrator is the character telling the story. The author invented that character on purpose, including their blind spots.
"How do I know he is unreliable?"	Look for places where what he says does not match what other characters do, or where he explains something nobody asked about. People over-explain when they know they are wrong.
"Is Theo a bad person?"	That is a real question and there is no set answer. Ask them what evidence they would need to decide. That is a better conversation than the answer.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page asks students to rewrite one scene as Nadia would tell it. It is the fastest way to prove they understood the lesson.

Read: The Second Chair

BEFORE YOU READ

This story is told by Theo. Watch for two things: places where what Theo **says** does not match what other people **do**, and places where Theo explains something nobody asked him about.

The Second Chair

Short fiction • written for this lesson

- 1 I want to say first that I did not take Nadia's spot. That is what people are saying and it is not what happened.
- 2 Here is what actually happened. Mr. Okafor posted the seating for the spring concert on a Thursday. First clarinet was Nadia, second was me, the way it had been since sixth grade. Everyone knew that. I knew that. I was fine with it, honestly, because Nadia is better than me and there is no point pretending otherwise.
- 3 Then on Friday she was not at rehearsal. She was not there Monday either. On Tuesday Mr. Okafor asked me to take first for the week, just to keep the section together, and I said sure, because what else do you say when a teacher asks you to do something.
- 4 It was one week. That is important.
- 5 When Nadia came back she went and sat in the second chair without saying anything to me. I said hey. She said hey. She did not look up. I remember thinking she probably had a lot going on, because you do not miss four days for no reason.
- 6 I did not ask her about it. I am not the kind of person who pushes into other people's business, and anyway she could have said something if she wanted to. The chair was right there. Mr. Okafor never said the swap was permanent. She could have just taken it back.
- 7 At the concert I played the solo in the third piece. It went well. My mom recorded it and afterward in the parking lot she said she was proud of me and I said thanks. Nadia's family left before the end, which I noticed but did not think much about, because people leave early all the time for all kinds of reasons.
- 8 On Monday Camille asked me why I did not give the chair back and I said I did not take it in the first place, which is true. Camille said that was not really an answer. I said it was the only answer there was. She said okay and then she did not sit with me at lunch.
- 9 A lot of people have opinions about this who were not in the room.
- 10 The thing is, I have thought about it and I keep landing in the same place. I did not do anything. I got asked and I said yes. If Nadia wanted the chair she should have said so, out loud, to Mr. Okafor, the way you are supposed to. That is not on me.
- 11 I still have the recording my mom made. I have not watched it.

Questions: The Second Chair

1 Who is telling this story, and what point of view is it? (first person / third person)

2 Theo says in paragraph 1 that he did not take Nadia's spot. Based on the whole story, is he telling the truth?

Careful. This is not a yes or no question.

3 Find two moments where what other characters do does not match what Theo says about the situation. Write the paragraph number and what they did.

4 The story ends: "I still have the recording my mom made. I have not watched it." Why does the author end here? What does that last line tell you that Theo never says?

This is the most important question on the page.

5 Paragraph 6 gives three separate reasons why Theo did not ask Nadia about it. Why might giving three reasons be a clue?

6 If this story were told by Mr. Okafor instead, what would you learn that Theo cannot tell you?

Go Further: Nadia's Version

TASK

Rewrite **paragraph 5** (the moment Nadia comes back and sits in the second chair) as **Nadia** would tell it, in first person. Same event. Same facts. Everything else can change.

BEFORE YOU WRITE, DECIDE

You do not know why Nadia was away, and neither does the reader. Decide privately what it was. You do not have to state it, but it should shape how she sees the room. That is what point of view actually is.

1 What is the single biggest difference between your version and Theo's? Not the facts. The feeling.

CHALLENGE

A narrator who is not telling the whole truth is called an **unreliable narrator**. Writers use them on purpose. What does a reader get from an unreliable narrator that they would not get from a narrator who told them everything straight? Answer in two or three sentences.

Answer Key: The Second Chair

QUESTION PAGE

1. Theo. First person, signalled by *I* and *me* throughout.
2. Technically true, and not the whole truth. He did not take the chair. He was given it and then never gave it back, which is the thing he keeps not addressing.
The target answer is the gap between technically true and honest. Accept a plain "no" if the student explains that keeping it and taking it amount to the same outcome.
3. Any two of: Nadia sits in second chair without speaking and does not look up (par. 5); Nadia's family leaves the concert early (par. 7); Camille says his answer is not really an answer and then stops sitting with him at lunch (par. 8).
Strong students notice that Theo reports every one of these accurately and then supplies an innocent explanation for it immediately afterward. Worth pointing out if it comes up.
4. Because he cannot watch it. If he genuinely believed he had done nothing wrong, the recording would be a good memory. The fact that it sits unwatched shows guilt he never admits in words. The author ends there because it is the one moment Theo's own account contradicts itself.
This is the question that shows whether the lesson landed. Full credit needs the idea that the action reveals what the words deny. Common weak answer: "he is busy" or "he forgot." Push back gently: he mentions it in the last line of his own story, so it is on his mind.
5. People over-explain when they are defending something. One reason sounds like a fact; three stacked reasons sound like someone trying to convince themselves.
6. Why Nadia was absent; whether Mr. Okafor ever intended the swap to be permanent; whether Nadia asked for her chair back and was refused; what Mr. Okafor noticed. Theo cannot tell us any of this, partly because he never asked.

GO FURTHER PAGE

Nadia's version: Strong rewrites keep every fact and change what is noticed: the walk to the chair, how long the silence lasted, what "hey" sounded like, whether Theo looked up. The best ones make the reader realize Theo's version was not neutral.

Do not mark for invented backstory. Mark for whether the same events now feel different.

Challenge: An unreliable narrator makes the reader do the work of judging, which is more involving than being told. It also lets the author show self-deception from the inside, which a truthful narrator cannot do.

IF THE DISCUSSION TURNS PERSONAL

Students sometimes connect this story to real situations in their own class. Keep it on Theo. "Let's stay with the story, and use the text as our evidence" redirects it cleanly without shutting anyone down.

The One-Paragraph Case

TEACHER BRIEFING • KEEP THIS PAGE

NO ENGLISH BACKGROUND NEEDED

Everything you need is on this page and the answer key. You do not need to have read anything in advance, and you do not need to know the students.

Copy for students: the next three pages. **Keep:** this page and the answer key.

What this lesson does

Students write one tightly structured argument paragraph using claim, evidence, reasoning. All the evidence they need is supplied on the student page, so no research is required and no student can be blocked by not knowing enough. This produces a piece of assessable writing inside a single period and is the strongest lesson to leave if you want graded work waiting when you return.

How the period runs

MIN	WHAT YOU DO
0-6	Read the opening lines below. Hand out all three student pages. Read the worked example aloud, slowly.
6-12	Students choose a question and pick three pieces of evidence from the bank.
12-40	Students draft the paragraph. This is the bulk of the period.
40-52	Go Further: the self-check and the counter-argument sentence.
52-55	Collect all pages. These are worth leaving in a neat pile.

SAY THIS TO START

You are writing one paragraph today. One. It has to do a specific job and it has to do it in a specific order. Every fact you need is printed on your page, so nobody is stuck for something to say. The only thing being tested is whether you can build an argument that holds.

The three questions students will ask

THEY ASK	YOU SAY
"Can I use my own evidence?"	Yes, as long as they also use at least two from the bank. The bank exists so nobody is stuck, not to limit them.
"How long should it be?"	Six to nine sentences. If it is three, they have skipped the reasoning. If it is fifteen, they have written two paragraphs.
"Do I have to actually believe it?"	No. Arguing a side you do not hold is a normal and useful exercise. Tell them to pick whichever side they can support best.

FINISHED EARLY?

The Go Further page is a self-check grid plus one hard extra sentence: naming the other side's best point and answering it.

The Structure and the Evidence Bank

PICK ONE QUESTION

A. Should middle schools ban phones during the entire school day? B. Should homework be graded, or only feedback? C. Should students be allowed to choose their own seats?

THE SHAPE OF THE PARAGRAPH

SENTENCE	ITS JOB
1. Claim	State your position in one clear sentence. No "I think". Just say it.
2. Evidence	Give a fact, example or consequence.
3. Reasoning	Explain why that fact supports your claim. This is the sentence students skip.
4. Evidence	A second, different fact.
5. Reasoning	Why that one supports the claim too.
6. Counter	"Some would argue that..." Name the other side's best point honestly.
7. Answer	Why your position still holds anyway.

WORKED EXAMPLE (QUESTION C)

Students should not choose their own seats in the first month of a school year. Teachers who assign seats report that they learn student names roughly twice as fast, because a fixed chart gives them a reliable map of the room. Names matter more than they appear to: a student who is called on by name in week two behaves as though they are known, and behaves accordingly. Assigned seating also breaks up the pattern where students who already know each other cluster together, which leaves new students with nowhere obvious to sit. A room where nobody is stranded on day one is worth more than a room where everyone got their first choice. Some would argue that being told where to sit is a small humiliation, and that students work better beside people they trust. That is true after the first month, which is exactly when the chart should come down.

EVIDENCE BANK • USE AT LEAST TWO

Q	YOU MAY USE ANY OF THESE AS EVIDENCE
A	A notification pulls attention away for longer than the glance itself takes • some schools using pouches report louder hallways and more conversation at lunch • a phone is also how a student contacts a parent in an emergency • enforcement falls unevenly on the students already most watched • students say the hardest part is the first week, then it stops mattering
B	A grade tells you where you stand; feedback tells you what to do next • students who know work is ungraded attempt harder problems • ungraded work is completed less often • grading every task takes teacher time that could go into comments • homework completion varies with what support exists at home
C	Teachers learn names faster with a fixed chart • friend groups cluster and leave new students stranded • students concentrate better next to people they chose • a chart can be changed; a habit cannot • some students need a specific spot for hearing or sight and a free-for-all can cost them it

Does every piece of evidence have a sentence after it explaining why it matters? And is your claim a **position** rather than a topic? "Phones in school" is a topic. "Phones should be collected at the classroom door" is a claim.

Go Further: Test Your Own Argument

TASK

Read your own paragraph back slowly and mark yourself honestly. Then fix whatever you marked **No**.

CHECK	YES	NO
My first sentence states a position, not a topic.		
I used at least two separate pieces of evidence.		
Every piece of evidence is followed by a sentence saying why it matters.		
I named the other side's best point, not their weakest.		
I answered it rather than just mentioning it.		
I did not write "I think" or "in my opinion" anywhere.		

THE HARDEST SENTENCE IN ARGUMENT WRITING

Most students name the other side's weakest point because it is easy to knock down. Strong writers do the opposite: they name the point that genuinely worries them, and answer it anyway. That is what makes a reader trust you.

Write it now. The single strongest argument against your own position, stated fairly, in one sentence:

And your honest answer to it:

CHALLENGE

Did writing the other side's best point change your mind at all, even slightly? Write one sentence about that. Saying yes is not losing.

Marking Guide: The One-Paragraph Case

THIS LESSON PRODUCES WRITING, NOT RIGHT ANSWERS

There is no key. Below is a rubric the returning teacher can use, and a fast circulating check you can use during the period without reading anything closely.

While circulating: the 10-second check

GLANCE AT	GOOD SIGN	INTERVENE
Sentence 1	A position you could disagree with	A topic, or starts with "I think"
Shape	Alternating fact, explanation, fact, explanation	A list of facts with no sentences between them
Near the end	"Some would argue..."	No counter-argument at all

THE ONE SENTENCE THAT FIXES MOST PARAGRAPHS

By a wide margin the most common failure is missing reasoning: students state a fact and move straight to the next fact. Point at any piece of evidence and ask:

"So what? Why does that prove your point?" Then tell them to write down what they just said.

Rubric for the returning teacher

	DESCRIPTOR
4	Clear arguable claim. Two or more relevant pieces of evidence, each followed by reasoning that genuinely connects it to the claim. Counter-argument is the strong version of the opposing case and is answered rather than dismissed. Reads as one controlled paragraph.
3	Clear claim, two pieces of evidence, reasoning present for at least one. Counter-argument named and given some answer. Solid single-period work.
2	Claim present. Evidence present but reasoning mostly missing, so the paragraph reads as a list. Counter-argument missing or is a straw man.
1	Opinion stated without evidence, or evidence copied from the bank with no argument built around it.

WORTH PASSING ON

The last question on the Go Further page asks whether writing the opposing view changed their mind. The answers are often the most interesting thing in the pile and are worth flagging for the returning teacher.

Emergency Day Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND LEAVE IT ON TOP

Fill in the blanks once, at the start of the year, and this page works for every absence after that.

NOTE FOR THE SUBSTITUTE

My name _____

Room / period _____

Teach this lesson Lesson # ____ (pages ____ to ____) or any lesson from the index

Teacher next door _____

Nearest bathroom / policy _____

Students who leave early _____

Students with accommodations _____

Seating, extra time, reader _____

Fire drill meeting point _____

Leave the work _____

Anything else _____

SUBSTITUTE: BEFORE YOU LEAVE, DO THESE THREE THINGS

1. Stack the collected work on the teacher's desk with this page on top.
2. Write the names of two or three students who were especially helpful. Teachers genuinely act on this.
3. Note anything the teacher should know, in one line. Not a report. One line.

SUBSTITUTE'S NOTE BACK TO THE TEACHER

Lesson taught _____

Got through All of it / Most of it / Page 1 only

Helpful students _____

Anything to know _____

REUSE NOTE

This pack is designed to be printed once and reused across many absences. Store the briefing pages and answer keys separately from the student pages so the wrong sheets never get photocopied.

COMMON CORE STATE STANDARDS • ELA GRADES 6-8

Each lesson is mapped to its primary standard. Most also touch secondary standards; the primary alignment is listed for clarity.

#	LESSON	PRIMARY SKILL	PRIMARY STANDARD
1	The Map Nobody Believed	Close reading and citing evidence	RI.6-8.1
2	What Is This Actually About?	Central idea and objective summary	RI.6-8.2
3	Word Attack	Context clues, roots, and prefixes	L.6-8.4
4	Take It Apart	Claim, evidence, and reasoning in an argument	RI.6-8.8
5	Two Reporters, One Fire Drill	Point of view, bias, and word choice	RI.6-8.6
6	The Six-Sentence Story	Narrative writing with a story spine	W.6-8.3
7	Sentence Surgery	Fragments, run-ons, and comma repair	L.6-8.1-2
8	Figurative Language Detective	Metaphor, simile, and hyperbole	RL.6-8.4
9	The Narrator Is Hiding Something	Point of view and reliability	RL.6-8.6
10	The One-Paragraph Case	Argument writing with CER	W.6-8.1

Coverage by strand

STRAND	LESSONS	WHAT IS COVERED
Reading: Informational Text	1, 2, 4, 5	Citing textual evidence, central idea and objective summary, evaluating argument and claims, author point of view and purpose
Reading: Literature	8, 9	Word meaning and figurative language in context, point of view and narrator reliability
Writing	6, 10	Narrative writing with structure and technique, argument writing with claim, evidence and reasoning
Language	3, 7	Determining word meaning from context and word parts, sentence structure and punctuation conventions

A NOTE ON STANDARDS

These lessons are skill lessons, not curriculum coverage. They are designed to be genuinely useful on a day the regular teacher is absent, without depending on where a class has reached in its own sequence. Every lesson stands alone and can be used at any point in the year.

Standards references are provided to help teachers document the day's instruction. This resource is independently created and is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or reviewed by any state agency, district, or standards body.

Terms of Use and Credits

THANK YOU

Thank you for buying this pack. It was written by a practicing teacher with more than twenty years in secondary classrooms, and every lesson in it is built the way I would want a sub plan built if I were the one waking up sick.

LEAVE FEEDBACK, EARN CREDITS

Teachers Pay Teachers gives you credit toward future purchases every time you review a resource you have bought. Most people never collect it. It takes about a minute.

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Open My Purchases

Sign in to TPT and find this resource in your purchase history.

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Click Provide Feedback

Leave a rating and a comment saying what worked.

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Collect the credit

It applies to your next purchase automatically.

The comment matters more than the stars. Volume 2 of this pack exists because teachers wrote about what they wanted next. If a lesson landed well, or one section was too easy, or you want a version for a different grade band, say so. It decides what gets built.

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OTHER PACKS IN THIS SERIES

Pack	What is in it
Middle School ELA • Volume 2	Ten further lessons, numbered 11 to 20. Media literacy, poetry, argument, word study, editing and written discussion. No overlap with this pack.
Middle School Math	Ten no-prep lessons with worked solutions, 57 pages.
Middle School Science	Ten no-prep lessons, no lab required, 57 pages.
Computer Science & Digital Technologies	Ten no-prep lessons, no devices required, 57 pages.

The **ELA Volumes 1 and 2 Bundle** takes both ELA packs at a discount off the combined price: twenty lessons, no repeated passage. All packs are also available as a full discounted bundle. Fill the drawer once.

GETTING THE MOST OUT OF THIS PACK

- **Print it before you need it.** The whole point is that it works on a morning when you cannot get out of bed to print anything.
- **Store it in two piles.** Student pages in one, briefing pages and answer keys in the other, so the wrong sheets never get copied by mistake.
- **Tell your office where it is.** On a genuine emergency day, the person who needs to find this is not you.
- **Use them when you are present too.** These work as standalone skill lessons, review days, and early-finisher work.

Credits. Written, designed and typeset by Clarence Goh. Set in Lato and JetBrains Mono. Digital Vector • digitalvector.com.au

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